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Hiring Committee
Ontario City Library
City of Ontario
200 North Cherry Avenue, Ontario, CA 91764

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Senior Library Assistant position with the Ontario City Library. I want to be straightforward at the start. Your posting asks for two years of technical or reference experience in a library, and I do not have that. What I do have is most of the work itself, built in a development office rather than a library, and the specific things your ideal candidate paragraph names, which are archival collections, digital collections and finding aids.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the collection I look after is the organization’s archive of everything it has printed and mailed to donors. I handle intake when samples come back from the printer, arrange and shelve the material by campaign and mail code, keep the arrangement intact as the collection grows across campaign years, and retrieve from it when a writer or a director needs a past piece.

When I inherited that archive, finding anything in it meant already knowing where it was. I designed a SQL database for the collection and defined a consistent record for every piece, so that a mail code or a campaign name would be enough to locate something, then worked back through several campaign years and described the existing material against that standard. On top of the database I built the finding aid, a searchable reading room that returns the piece and tells you where the physical original sits. That is archival processing and description, and I did it because the collection was unusable without it.

I have built two public websites on the same principle. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and built the catalog that readers search. I also developed statetrack.net, a service that publishes state campaign finance records for state house and state senate candidates in all fifty states, which meant normalizing inconsistent records from fifty different reporting regimes into something a visitor can actually search.

The supervisory and program sides of this role are familiar ground. As West Deputy Regional Director at Young Americans for Liberty I supervised six state chairs and oversaw campus chapters across Arizona, Nevada and California, ran weekly meetings with them, and trained student leaders and volunteers to deliver programs themselves. As California State Chair before that I organized and ran more than thirty programs, recruitment drives and chapter meetings, and was the primary liaison for over ninety dues-paying members. I have also prepared promotional material, tracked budgets against vendor invoices, and reported on whether a program reached anyone.

The public-facing side goes back further. At the University of Austin I handled intake and documentation of donated book collections for the campus library, including a complete *Harvard Classics* set I carried from the first conversation with the donor through to the books being shelved, and I led donor tours of the collection. Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to and processed more than five hundred records accurately and in confidence.

I hold a valid Class C California driver’s license with a clean record, and I can work evening and weekend shifts. I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I have family in Southern California who can host me during an interim move, which makes getting out there straightforward.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I know I am short of the stated experience minimum, and I would rather you weigh that against the archival and digital work than have me pretend otherwise. Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie